

A FIELD PROJECT REPORT

ON

SOCIAL MEDIA SAFETY & DIGITAL FOOTPRINT AWARENESS

A Community-Level Survey of 55 Respondents on Online Safety Practices

Submitted in partial fulfilment of the requirements of the

COMMUNITY ENGAGEMENT PROJECT (CEP)

B.Sc. (Information Technology) | Semester V | Academic Year 2026-2027

Submitted by : _____

Roll No. : _____

Project Guide / Mentor : _____

**PRAHLADRAI DALMIA LIONS COLLEGE OF
COMMERCE & ECONOMICS**

Affiliated to the University of Mumbai | NAAC 'A' Grade (III Cycle)

Submitted: September 2026

CERTIFICATE BY THE INSTITUTE AND MENTOR

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This is to certify that Mr./Ms. _____, bearing Roll No. _____, a bona fide student of Prahladrai Dalmia Lions College of Commerce & Economics, studying in B.Sc. (Information Technology), Semester V, has satisfactorily completed the field project titled "Social Media Safety & Digital Footprint Awareness" in the area of the Community Engagement Project for the academic year 2026–2027.

The project involved the design of a 21-item structured questionnaire, field administration to 55 respondents, tabulation and statistical analysis of the responses, and the preparation of this report under institutional supervision.

To the best of my knowledge, the work submitted by the student is original, was carried out under my guidance, and the information included in this report is correct. The report has not been submitted earlier for the award of any other degree, diploma or certificate.

Internal Guide / Mentor	Head of the Department	Principal
Signature: _____	Signature: _____	Signature: _____
Name: _____	Name: _____	Name: _____

Date: _____

Place: _____

College Seal

STUDENT'S DECLARATION

I, Mr./Ms. _____, bearing Roll No. _____, a student of Prahladrai Dalmia Lions College of Commerce & Economics, studying in B.Sc. (Information Technology), Semester V, hereby declare that I have completed the field project entitled "Social Media Safety & Digital Footprint Awareness" during the academic year 2026–2027 as part of the Community Engagement Project.

I further declare that:

- The work presented in this report is my own and has been carried out under the guidance of my project mentor.
- The information and data included in this report are true and have emerged from the primary data collected through the field survey of 55 respondents and from the secondary sources consulted during the study.
- Participation in the survey was voluntary, respondents were informed of the academic purpose of the study, and no personally identifying information was recorded.
- Due credit has been extended to all secondary sources by acknowledging them in the References section in the prescribed format.
- This report, in whole or in part, has not been submitted to this or any other institution for the award of any degree, diploma or certificate.

Signature of the Student: _____

Name of the Student: _____

Roll No.: _____ Date: _____

ACKNOWLEDGEMENT

The completion of this field project would not have been possible without the support, guidance and cooperation of a number of individuals and institutions, and I take this opportunity to record my sincere gratitude to all of them.

I thank the University of Mumbai for including the Community Engagement Project in the curriculum, which gave me the opportunity to move beyond classroom learning and engage directly with a community on an issue of everyday relevance.

I am grateful to our Principal, Prof. (Dr.) D. N. Ganjewar, and our Vice-Principal, Ms. Subhashini Naikar, for providing the academic environment and the facilities necessary for the completion of this project.

I extend my thanks to our coordinator, CA Durgesh Y. Kenkre, for his encouragement, administrative support and timely guidance throughout the project period.

I owe a special debt of gratitude to my project guide, _____, whose careful supervision, suggestions on questionnaire design and patient review of the analysis shaped this report at every stage.

I sincerely thank the 55 respondents who gave their time to complete the questionnaire and who participated in the interaction sessions with candour and interest. Their responses form the foundation of this study.

I also thank the staff of the college library and computer laboratory for access to reference material and to the systems used for data entry and analysis.

Finally, I thank my parents and my peers for their constant encouragement and support throughout the duration of this project.

ABSTRACT

This field project examines social media safety and digital footprint awareness among young social media users through a descriptive survey conducted as part of the Community Engagement Project. A structured 21-item questionnaire was designed and administered to 55 respondents drawn from a college and its surrounding community using convenience sampling. The instrument covered daily usage patterns, platforms used, purposes of use, account privacy, password practices, two-factor authentication, experience with suspicious messages and links, reflection before posting, understanding of the digital footprint, public sharing of personal information, review of privacy settings, knowledge of blocking and reporting tools, perceived risks, confidence in identifying scams, behaviour change, and interest in further learning. Responses were tabulated as frequencies and percentages and presented through twenty-two figures.

The findings show intensive engagement with social media: 60.0 per cent of respondents spend more than three hours online daily, and WhatsApp, Instagram and YouTube are the dominant platforms. Awareness of risk is high — 80.0 per cent believe their posts can affect future education or employment opportunities and 76.4 per cent know how to block or report an account. Protective practice, however, lags behind awareness: only 41.8 per cent have enabled two-factor authentication, 23.6 per cent review privacy settings regularly, and 40.0 per cent do not clearly understand the term “digital footprint”. Although 81.8 per cent have encountered a suspicious message or request, one in five is unsure how to respond safely.

The study concludes that the principal gap in this community is not awareness but translation of awareness into habit. It recommends hands-on digital-safety workshops, guided demonstrations of privacy controls and two-factor authentication, scam identification drills using real cases, and a periodic digital-footprint review exercise. Interest in such interventions is strong, with 74.5 per cent of respondents willing to attend a dedicated session.

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CHAPTER 1 — INTRODUCTION

1.1 Background of the Study

Social media has become an ordinary part of daily life. Communication with family and friends, access to news, entertainment, study material, shopping and professional networking now pass routinely through a small number of platforms carried in the pocket. Nearly all young users are online every day, and a substantial proportion describe themselves as online almost constantly; in the United States, for instance, 96 per cent of teenagers use the internet daily and close to half report near-constant use (Pew Research Center, 2024).

This convenience carries obligations that are easy to overlook. Information published online can travel far beyond its intended audience, be copied, reshared or archived, and remain retrievable long after the moment that produced it. Social media safety refers to the set of habits and controls that reduce the risks of such exposure: strong and unique passwords, two-factor authentication, restrained sharing of personal details, periodic review of privacy settings, cautious handling of unfamiliar links and requests, and confident use of blocking and reporting tools. Digital footprint awareness extends this idea further, encouraging users to recognise that their posts, comments, reactions and search activity accumulate into a persistent record that others may later read.

1.2 Need for the Study

The need for this study arises from a practical observation made during preliminary conversations in the community. Most young users can describe online risks in general terms, yet many continue to reuse passwords, leave accounts publicly visible, accept requests from unfamiliar accounts, or share location and daily routine without pausing. General awareness, in other words, does not automatically produce protective behaviour.

A structured field survey allows this difference to be measured rather than assumed. By asking respondents both what they know and what they actually do, the study can identify precisely where an awareness intervention would add value, and can convert an impression shared in conversation into evidence that a college or community body can act upon.

1.3 Objectives of the Study

1. To assess the pattern and intensity of social media usage among respondents, including time spent, platforms used and purposes of use.
2. To examine respondents' account-security practices with reference to account privacy, password strength and two-factor authentication.
3. To measure awareness of the concept of the digital footprint and of the possible effect of online activity on future educational and employment opportunities.
4. To identify the risks respondents perceive as most serious and to record how they respond to suspicious messages, links and requests.
5. To determine the extent to which awareness of risk has translated into changed online behaviour, thereby locating the awareness-to-action gap.

6. To develop practical, community-level recommendations for safer and more responsible social media use.

1.4 Scope of the Study

The study is limited to everyday, user-level social media safety and digital footprint awareness. Fifty-five respondents from a college and its immediate neighbourhood in Mumbai were surveyed during August 2026. The study covers behaviour and awareness as reported by respondents themselves.

The study does not attempt a technical security audit of any platform, does not inspect or test individual accounts, and does not collect credentials or other sensitive identifiers. Its findings describe this particular community at this particular time and are intended to guide local awareness activity rather than to support broad generalisation.

1.5 Significance of the Study

The study is significant in three respects. For respondents, the act of answering the questionnaire prompted reflection on habits that are usually automatic, and several participants reviewed their privacy settings during the interaction itself. For the institution, the findings identify the specific topics — two-factor authentication, privacy-setting review and scam identification — where a short workshop would produce the greatest benefit. For the discipline, the study contributes a small, locally grounded data point to the wider literature on the gap between digital-risk awareness and protective practice.

1.6 Organisation of the Report

Chapter 1 introduces the topic, the need for the study, its objectives and scope. Chapter 2 reviews the relevant literature and secondary data on social media use, account security, digital footprints and cybercrime. Chapter 3 sets out the methodology, including questionnaire design, sampling, data processing, ethics and limitations. Chapter 4 records the community interaction and presents the question-wise analysis of all 55 responses with supporting tables and figures. Chapter 5 draws conclusions and offers recommendations and an action plan. The References and three appendices — the questionnaire, the raw response matrix and the fieldwork evidence record — follow.

CHAPTER 2 — LITERATURE REVIEW

This chapter reviews published research, official statistics and public digital-safety guidance relevant to the present study. The review is organised around five themes: the place of social media in everyday life, account security and privacy controls, the concept of the digital footprint, the risk and cybercrime environment, and the gap between awareness and action.

2.1 Social Media in Everyday Life

Survey evidence consistently shows very high and habitual platform engagement among young users. The Pew Research Center's 2024 study of 1,391 American teenagers found that 90 per cent use YouTube, roughly 60 per cent use TikTok and Instagram, and 55 per cent use Snapchat, while Facebook use has fallen to 32 per cent from 71 per cent a decade earlier (Pew Research Center, 2024). Around one-third of teenagers report using at least one platform almost constantly. Studies in Indian and other South Asian settings report a comparable dominance of messaging applications, with WhatsApp typically the most widely used platform.

Two features of this literature are relevant here. First, usage is measured in hours per day rather than occasional visits, which means that exposure to risk is continuous rather than episodic. Second, platform preference varies by age and social group, so awareness material designed for one cohort may not reach another.

2.2 Account Security and Privacy Controls

The security literature and platform guidance converge on a small set of high-value controls: unique passwords for each service, multi-factor authentication, careful management of recovery details, and alertness to unexpected login notifications. Multi-factor authentication is widely described as the single most effective consumer control against account takeover, yet adoption surveys repeatedly find that a large share of users have never enabled it, most commonly citing inconvenience or unfamiliarity rather than disagreement with its value (Cybercrime Support Network, 2023).

Privacy settings offer a second layer of control by limiting who may view a profile, posts, contact details and activity. Survelioglu and Seferoglu (2019) found that while 91.2 per cent of the higher-education students they surveyed said they were aware of privacy settings, only 78.6 per cent reported checking and adjusting them regularly — an early indication that awareness and routine practice diverge even within the same sample. Technical controls, in short, protect users only when they are understood and applied consistently.

2.3 The Concept of the Digital Footprint

A digital footprint is the accumulated record of traces a person leaves online: posts, comments, photographs, reactions, memberships, public profile fields and the data trail generated by searching and browsing. The literature distinguishes an active footprint, deliberately published by the user, from a passive footprint, collected by platforms and third parties during ordinary use.

Survelioglu and Seferoglu (2019), surveying 508 students across 41 universities, reported high overall digital-footprint awareness (mean 4.25 on a five-point scale) but markedly lower familiarity with the term itself (mean 3.17), with 35.0 per cent of students disagreeing that they were aware of the concept. Awareness rose with age, year of study and self-rated digital competence. Their respondents identified chat applications (90.7 per cent) and social networks (83.9 per cent) as the environments in which they most often left traces. The practical implication is that the underlying idea may be partly understood even where the vocabulary is unfamiliar, and that awareness material should therefore teach the concept rather than merely name it.

2.4 Online Risks and the Indian Cybercrime Context

Commonly documented risks include phishing, fake and impersonating accounts, identity theft, account takeover, cyberbullying and harassment, financial fraud, unwanted data collection and misinformation. Social engineering is particularly relevant to this study because it exploits urgency, curiosity, fear or trust rather than technical weakness, which places the user rather than the system at the point of defence.

Official Indian data show a steep rise in recorded offences. Cybercrime cases registered in India increased from 50,035 in 2020 to 101,928 in 2024, slightly more than doubling in four years, with fraud (29,758 cases) and cheating (19,296 cases) the largest heads in 2024 and 266 cases registered specifically for fake profiles (Ministry of Home Affairs, 2026). Between 2021 and 2025, more than 6.58 million financial-fraud complaints were filed on the National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal, involving amounts exceeding ₹55,050 crore. The Government has responded institutionally through the Indian Cybercrime Coordination Centre, the Citizen Financial Cyber Fraud Reporting and Management System and the 1930 helpline, and legislatively through the Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023 (Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology, 2023).

Two observations follow. The scale of recorded fraud confirms that the risks named in awareness material are real and locally present, not hypothetical. And the existence of a reporting portal and a helpline means that a concrete, actionable step exists which many users are simply unaware of.

2.5 The Awareness-to-Action Gap

A recurring finding across the digital-safety literature is that knowing about a risk does not reliably change behaviour. The privacy paradox describes the well-documented mismatch between the concern users express about privacy and the disclosure they practise. Explanations offered include the immediacy of social reward against the abstraction of future harm, the perceived effort of security steps, optimism bias about personal vulnerability, and simple habit.

This has a direct methodological consequence, adopted in the present study: a survey that asks only about knowledge will overstate safety. Awareness questions must be paired with behaviour questions so that the two can be compared directly.

2.6 Research Gap and Relevance to the Present Study

Two gaps are apparent. First, much of the available survey evidence is drawn from American or European samples, or from large national datasets that cannot describe a specific local community.

Second, studies frequently measure awareness and behaviour separately without placing them side by side for the same respondents.

The present study addresses both at a modest scale. It surveys a defined local community of 55 respondents, and it deliberately pairs awareness items — understanding of the digital footprint, belief that posts affect future opportunities, knowledge of blocking and reporting — with matching behaviour items on two-factor authentication, password practice and privacy-setting review, so that the gap between the two can be quantified for the same group. This comparison is presented in Section 4.5.

CHAPTER 3 — METHODOLOGY

3.1 Research Design

The study adopts a descriptive survey design, appropriate where the aim is to record and summarise existing awareness and behaviour rather than to test a causal hypothesis. A structured questionnaire was administered once to each respondent, producing cross-sectional quantitative data supported by qualitative observations recorded during the community interaction. Analysis is descriptive, using frequencies, percentages and graphical presentation, with a direct comparison of paired awareness and practice indicators.

3.2 Questionnaire Design

The questionnaire contains 21 items grouped into six thematic blocks. Most items use single-choice responses; three use checkbox-style multiple selection; one uses a five-point confidence scale; and one is open-ended. The instrument was drafted in English, kept deliberately short to suit field administration, and pilot-tested with five respondents whose feedback led to the simplification of the wording of two items. The complete instrument is reproduced in Appendix A.

Table 1: Structure of the questionnaire

Block	Theme	Items	Response type
A	Respondent profile	Q1–Q2	Single choice
B	Usage pattern and platforms	Q3–Q5	Single choice; multiple selection
C	Account security practices	Q6–Q8	Single choice
D	Threat exposure and response	Q9–Q10, Q17–Q18	Single choice; multiple selection; 5-point scale
E	Digital footprint awareness	Q11–Q14	Single choice
F	Privacy management and learning	Q15–Q16, Q19–Q21	Single choice; open-ended

3.3 Population, Sample and Sampling Technique

The population for the study consists of active social media users in the college and its surrounding community. A sample of 55 respondents was drawn using convenience sampling, an approach suited to a time-bound academic field project in which respondents must be accessible in person or through college networks. A minimum of 50 completed responses was set as the target before analysis began, in order to keep percentage estimates reasonably stable; 58 questionnaires were distributed and 55 usable responses were obtained, a response rate of 94.8 per cent. Three returns were excluded as incomplete.

The realised sample is dominated by college students aged 18 to 24, with a smaller presence of school students, working professionals and other community members. This composition reflects

the setting of the study and is reported transparently rather than presented as representative of the wider population.

Table 2: Composition of the sample (n = 55)

Characteristic	Category	Respondents	Percentage
Age	13–17 years	6	10.9%
	18–24 years	41	74.5%
	25–34 years	6	10.9%
	35–44 years	2	3.6%
Occupation	College/university student	42	76.4%
	School student	6	10.9%
	Working professional	5	9.1%
	Other	2	3.6%
Total	—	55	100.0%

3.4 Data Collection Procedure

Primary data were collected between 4 and 22 August 2026. The questionnaire was prepared in Google Forms and administered in two ways: in person on the college campus and in the surrounding neighbourhood using a mobile device, and through a shared link circulated to community contacts. Each respondent was told the purpose of the study, informed that participation was voluntary and anonymous, and given an opportunity to ask questions before beginning. Average completion time was six to eight minutes. Secondary data were obtained from peer-reviewed journal articles, published survey reports and official government statistics, all listed in the References.

3.5 Data Processing and Method of Analysis

Responses were exported from Google Forms to a spreadsheet, checked for completeness and coded. Frequency counts were computed for every item, and percentages for single-choice items were calculated on a base of 55 respondents. For the three multiple-selection items, each option was counted separately and the percentage reported is the share of respondents choosing that option; totals for these items therefore exceed 100 per cent and the number of selections exceeds 55. Percentages are rounded to one decimal place, so column totals may differ from 100.0 per cent by a rounding margin. Charts were prepared for all 21 items, together with a summary comparison chart. In each frequency table the options are ordered from the most to the least frequently chosen.

3.6 Validity and Reliability

Content validity was addressed by deriving the items from established digital-safety guidance and from the constructs used in prior studies, and by review of the draft instrument by the project guide. The pilot test with five respondents checked that wording was unambiguous and that response options were exhaustive and mutually exclusive. Because the questionnaire measures a

set of related but distinct behaviours rather than a single latent trait, internal-consistency coefficients were not computed. Consistency of administration was maintained by using an identical instrument and a standard verbal introduction for every respondent.

3.7 Ethical Considerations

- Participation was entirely voluntary and respondents could withdraw at any point without giving a reason.
- The academic purpose of the survey was explained before administration, and verbal consent was obtained.
- No names, passwords, account handles, phone numbers, addresses or other identifying details were collected; responses are identified in Appendix B only by a serial code.
- Respondents below 18 years of age were surveyed only in the presence of, and with the agreement of, a teacher or parent.
- Data were stored in a password-protected file used solely for this project.
- Any photographs included in Appendix C were taken with the express permission of the persons appearing in them.

3.8 Limitations of the Study

- The sample of 55 respondents is small and was selected by convenience, so the results describe this community and cannot be generalised to all social media users.
- The sample is weighted towards college students aged 18 to 24; school students, older adults and non-student community members are under-represented.
- All data are self-reported. Respondents may overstate safe behaviour in the presence of an interviewer, so reported protective practice should be read as an upper estimate.
- The study is cross-sectional and records a single point in time; it cannot measure whether behaviour changed after the interaction.
- The questionnaire was administered in English, which may have limited participation by some community members.
- The open-ended item was coded into five categories by the researcher alone, so a degree of subjectivity in coding cannot be ruled out.

CHAPTER 4 — COMMUNITY INTERACTION, OBSERVATIONS AND ANALYSIS

4.1 Community Interaction and Field Process

The fieldwork was carried out in three phases. In the preparatory phase the topic was finalised with the project guide, the questionnaire was drafted and pilot-tested, and permission was obtained to approach respondents on the college campus. In the interaction phase, conducted between 4 and 22 August 2026, respondents were approached individually and in small groups in the college corridors and library, and in the surrounding residential neighbourhood. Each interaction began with a short explanation of what a digital footprint is, followed by administration of the questionnaire and a brief discussion. In the concluding phase the responses were compiled, verified and analysed.

The discussions were as instructive as the questionnaire itself, and four observations recurred often enough to be recorded here.

- Several respondents had not encountered the term “digital footprint” before, but recognised the idea immediately once it was described in terms of old photographs and comments still being visible years later.
- Two-factor authentication was frequently confused with the one-time passwords used in banking. Respondents who used OTPs daily were often unaware that the same protection could be enabled on a social media account, and a common response was that it seemed troublesome rather than unnecessary.
- Respondents readily described suspicious messages they had received — lottery notifications, job offers, fake customer-care numbers and requests from duplicate profiles of people they knew — indicating that exposure to fraud attempts is a normal part of daily platform use.
- A number of respondents opened their privacy settings during the conversation itself, and several were surprised by how much of their profile was publicly visible. This suggests that a guided, hands-on demonstration is likely to be more effective than a lecture.

These observations are qualitative and are reported to provide context for the numerical findings that follow. A record of the fieldwork, including the photograph log, is placed in Appendix C.

4.2 Profile of the Respondents

Of the 55 respondents, 41 (74.5 per cent) are aged between 18 and 24 years and 42 (76.4 per cent) are college or university students. Six respondents are school students, five are working professionals and two described themselves as belonging to another category. Nine respondents (16.4 per cent) are therefore outside the typical undergraduate profile, which allowed a limited comparison across groups during the interaction. The full composition is set out in Table 2.

4.3 Summary of Key Indicators

Table 3 brings together the headline indicators from the survey before the item-by-item analysis. Read together, these figures describe a group that is heavily engaged with social media, largely conscious of reputational risk, and considerably less consistent in applying technical protections.

Table 3: Summary of key indicators from the field survey

Indicator	Respondents	Percentage
Total usable responses	55	100.0%
Aged 18–24 years	41	74.5%
Spend more than 3 hours daily on social media	33	60.0%
Main account set to private	36	65.5%
Use a strong, unique password	30	54.5%
Two-factor authentication enabled	23	41.8%
Have received a suspicious message, link or request	45	81.8%
Understand the term “digital footprint”	33	60.0%
Believe posts can affect future opportunities	44	80.0%
Review privacy settings regularly	13	23.6%
Know how to block or report an account	42	76.4%
Changed an online habit after learning of a risk	28	50.9%
Interested in attending an awareness session	41	74.5%

4.4 Question-wise Analysis and Interpretation

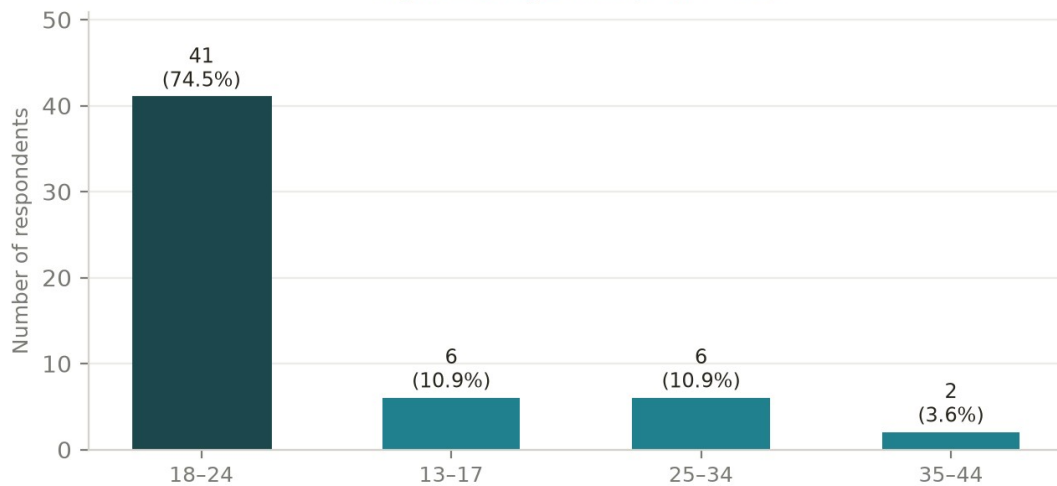
Each of the 21 items is presented below with its frequency distribution, a chart and a short interpretation. Percentages for single-choice items are calculated on a base of 55 respondents.

4.4.1 Q1 — Age Group

Q1. What is your age group?

Table 4: Q1 — Age Group: frequency distribution

Response option	Count	Percentage of respondents
18–24	41	74.5%
13–17	6	10.9%
25–34	6	10.9%
35–44	2	3.6%

Figure 1: Age Group (n = 55)**Figure 1: Age Group**

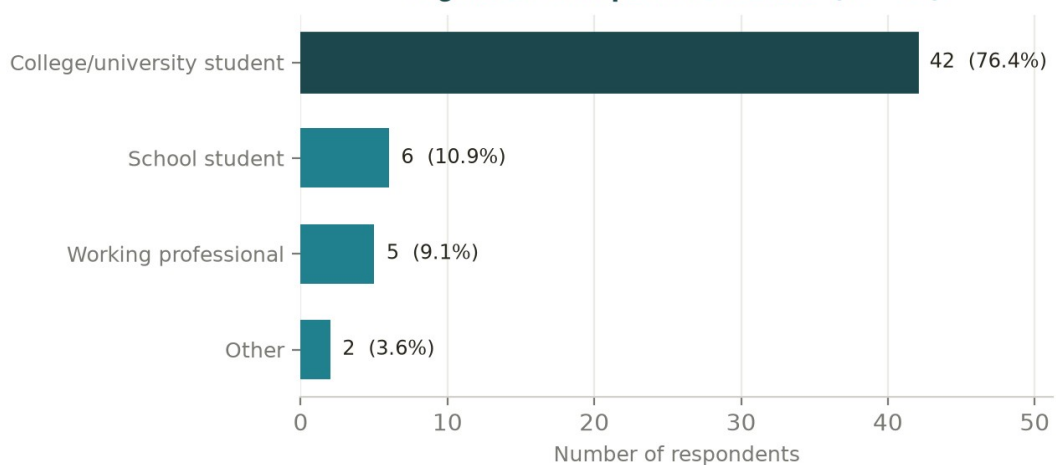
The sample is concentrated in the 18–24 age band, which accounts for 41 of 55 respondents. Six respondents fall in the 13–17 band and eight are aged 25 or above, so the findings principally describe young adults while retaining a small comparison group at either end.

4.4.2 Q2 — Occupation / Status

Q2. What is your current occupation or status?

Table 5: Q2 — Occupation / Status: frequency distribution

Response option	Count	Percentage of respondents
College/university student	42	76.4%
School student	6	10.9%
Working professional	5	9.1%
Other	2	3.6%

Figure 2: Occupation / Status (n = 55)**Figure 2: Occupation / Status**

Occupation mirrors the age profile: 42 respondents are college or university students. The 13 non-undergraduate respondents were valuable during the interaction, as working professionals were noticeably more likely to describe using two-factor authentication on financial accounts than on social accounts.

4.4.3 Q3 — Daily Social-Media Usage

Q3. On average, how much time do you spend on social media each day?

Table 6: Q3 — Daily Social-Media Usage: frequency distribution

Response option	Count	Percentage of respondents
3–5 hours per day	22	40.0%
1–3 hours per day	19	34.5%
More than 5 hours per day	11	20.0%
Less than 1 hour per day	3	5.5%

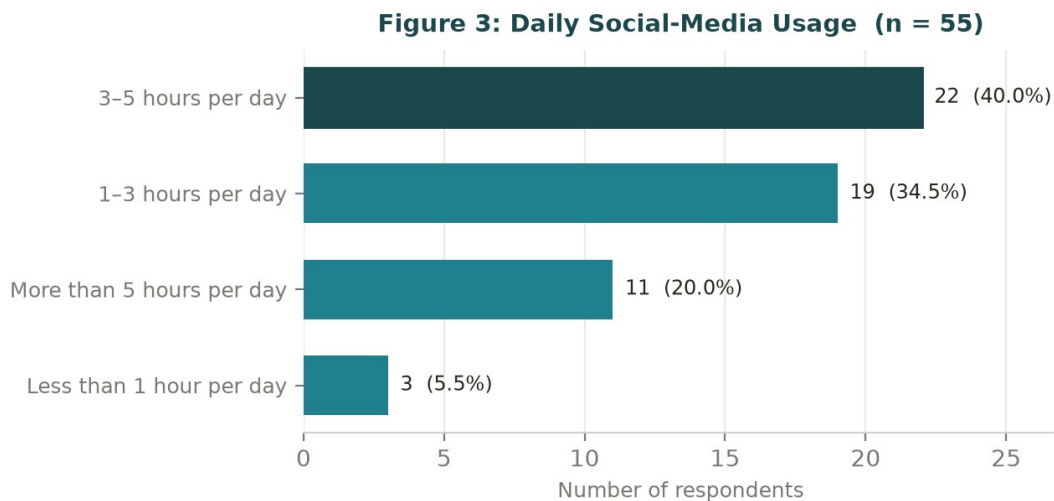


Figure 3: Daily Social-Media Usage

Sixty per cent of respondents spend more than three hours a day on social media, and 11 spend more than five. Only three report less than an hour. Exposure at this intensity means that unsafe habits are repeated many times each day, which strengthens the case for changing defaults such as account privacy and two-factor authentication rather than relying on vigilance in the moment.

4.4.4 Q4 — Platforms Used Most Frequently

Q4. Which social-media platforms do you use most frequently? (Select all that apply)

Table 7: Q4 — Platforms Used Most Frequently: frequency distribution

Response option	Count	Percentage of respondents
WhatsApp	51	92.7%
Instagram	49	89.1%
YouTube	44	80.0%
Snapchat	28	50.9%
X (Twitter)	21	38.2%

Response option	Count	Percentage of respondents
LinkedIn	19	34.5%
Facebook	14	25.5%
Telegram	12	21.8%

Multiple-selection item: respondents could choose more than one option, so the 238 selections recorded exceed the 55 respondents and the percentages sum to more than 100 per cent.

Figure 4: Platforms Used Most Frequently (n = 55)

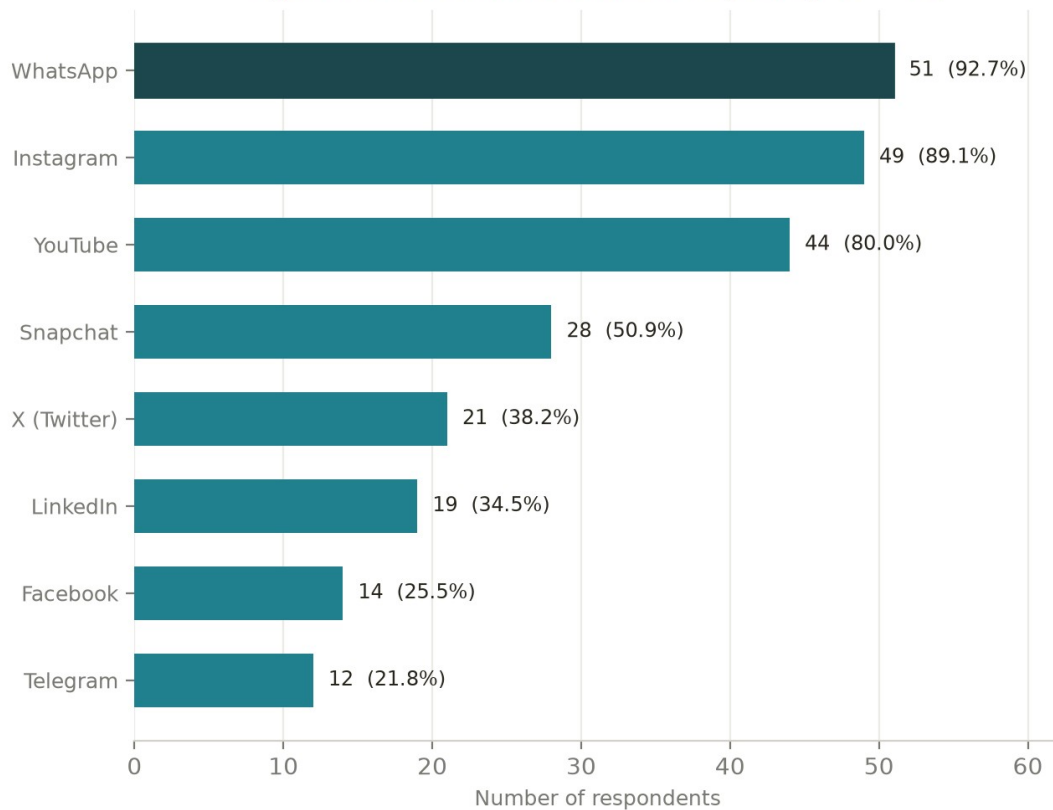


Figure 4: Platforms Used Most Frequently

WhatsApp (51 respondents) and Instagram (49) are close to universal, followed by YouTube (44). Facebook, at 14 respondents, is now a minority platform in this group. Awareness material should therefore be built around the privacy and reporting controls of WhatsApp and Instagram specifically, since guidance framed around Facebook would reach only a quarter of respondents.

4.4.5 Q5 — Primary Purpose of Use

Q5. What do you mainly use social media for? (Select all that apply)

Table 8: Q5 — Primary Purpose of Use: frequency distribution

Response option	Count	Percentage of respondents
Communication with friends and family	46	83.6%
Entertainment	43	78.2%
News and information	33	60.0%
Education and study material	27	49.1%

Response option	Count	Percentage of respondents
Content creation	15	27.3%
Professional networking	14	25.5%
Online shopping	12	21.8%

Multiple-selection item: respondents could choose more than one option, so the 190 selections recorded exceed the 55 respondents and the percentages sum to more than 100 per cent.

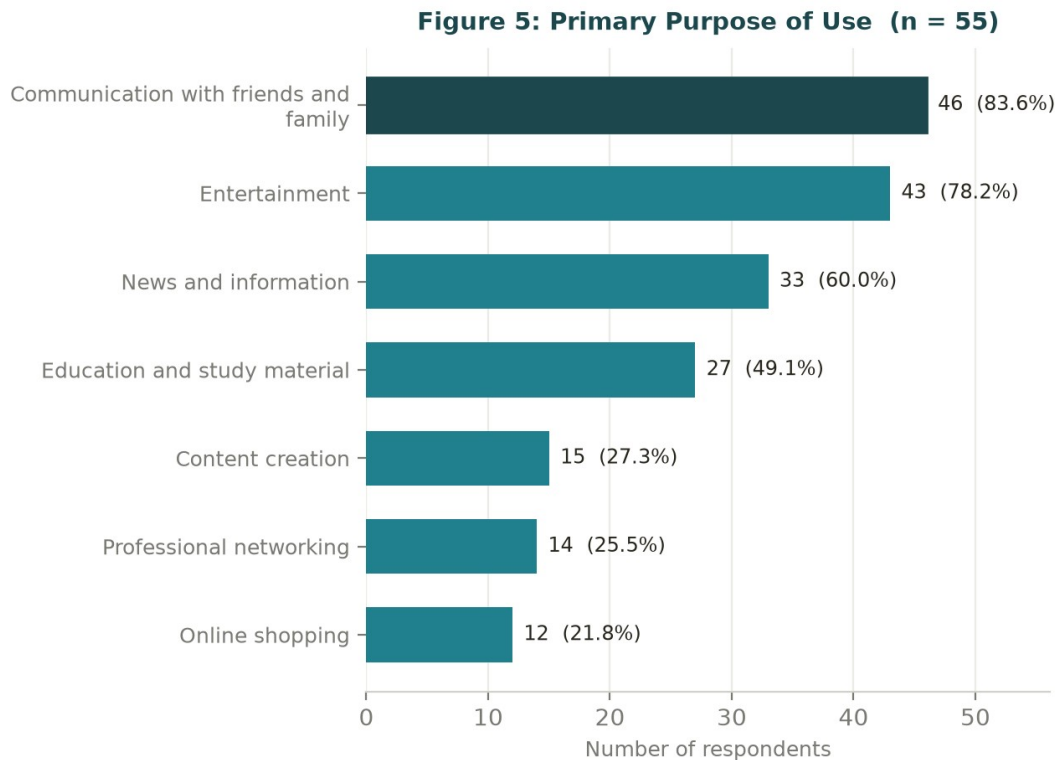


Figure 5: Primary Purpose of Use

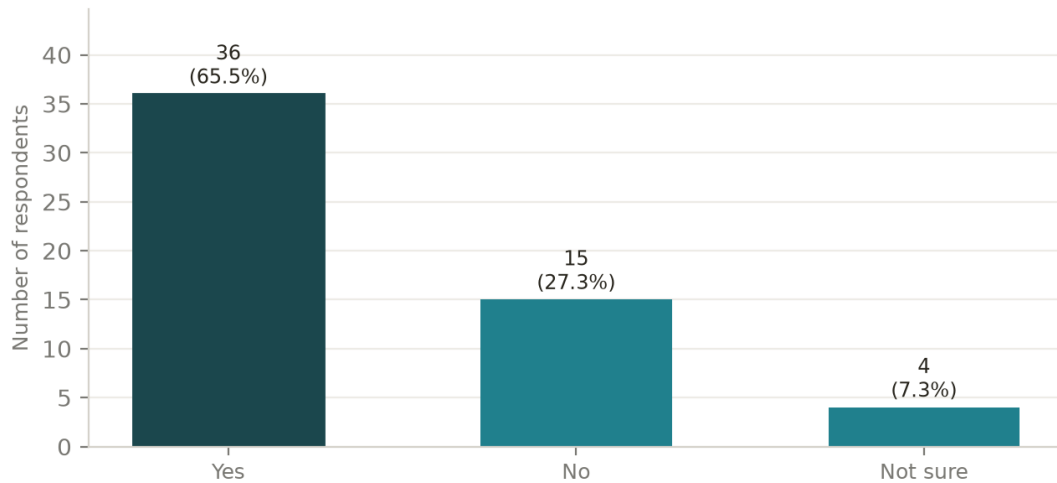
Communication (46) and entertainment (43) dominate, but 33 respondents rely on social media for news and information and 27 for study material. This matters for digital safety: platforms used as information sources expose users to misinformation as well as to fraud, and 14 respondents also use them for professional networking, where a public footprint carries direct career consequences.

4.4.6 Q6 — Account Privacy Status

Q6. Is your main social-media account set to private?

Table 9: Q6 — Account Privacy Status: frequency distribution

Response option	Count	Percentage of respondents
Yes	36	65.5%
No	15	27.3%
Not sure	4	7.3%

Figure 6: Account Privacy Status (n = 55)**Figure 6: Account Privacy Status**

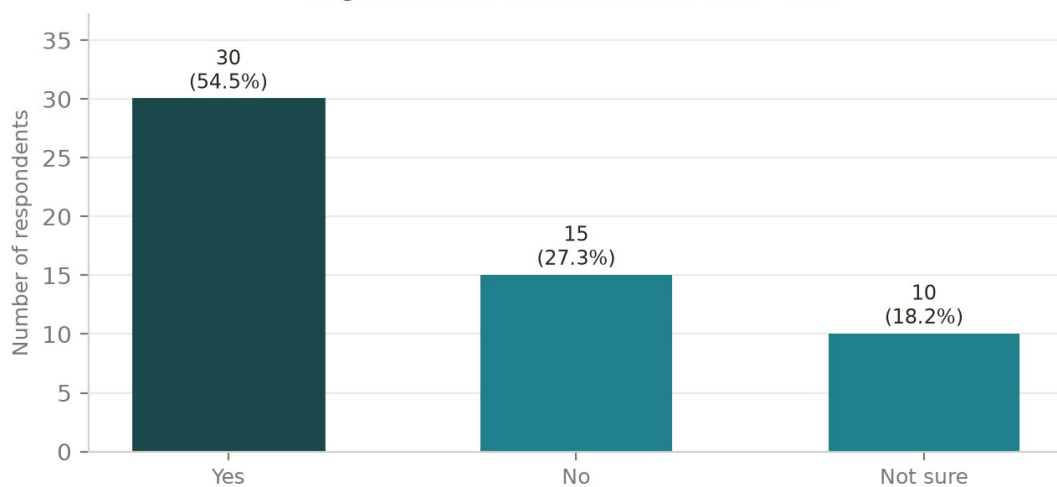
Thirty-six respondents (65.5 per cent) keep their main account private, but 15 keep it public and four are unsure. That roughly one in three respondents either has a public account or does not know its status is significant, because privacy status is the single setting that determines the default reach of everything else they post.

4.4.7 Q7 — Password Practices

Q7. Do you use a strong and unique password for your social-media accounts?

Table 10: Q7 — Password Practices: frequency distribution

Response option	Count	Percentage of respondents
Yes	30	54.5%
No	15	27.3%
Not sure	10	18.2%

Figure 7: Password Practices (n = 55)**Figure 7: Password Practices**

Just over half (54.5 per cent) report using a strong, unique password, while 15 say they do not and 10 are unsure. The 10 uncertain responses are notable in themselves: uncertainty about one's own password practice usually indicates password reuse across services, which converts a single breach into a chain of compromised accounts.

4.4.8 Q8 — Two-Factor Authentication

Q8. Have you enabled two-factor authentication (2FA) on your accounts?

Table 11: Q8 — Two-Factor Authentication: frequency distribution

Response option	Count	Percentage of respondents
No	24	43.6%
Yes	23	41.8%
I don't know what 2FA is	8	14.5%

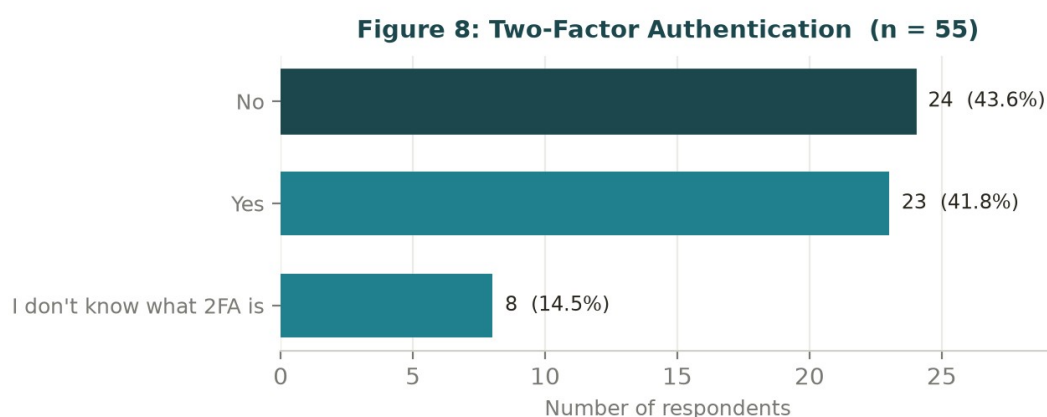


Figure 8: Two-Factor Authentication

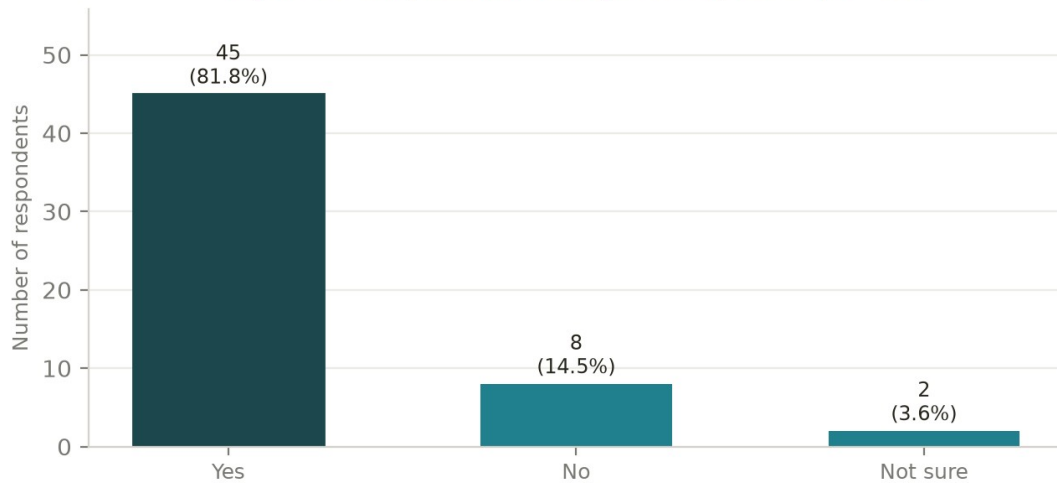
This is the weakest indicator in the study. Only 23 respondents (41.8 per cent) have enabled two-factor authentication, 24 have not, and eight do not know what it is. Since 2FA is the single most effective protection against account takeover available to an ordinary user, a majority of this community lacks its most valuable safeguard. The interaction suggested that the obstacle is perceived inconvenience and unfamiliarity rather than any objection in principle, which makes a guided setup demonstration a high-value intervention.

4.4.9 Q9 — Suspicious Messages / Requests

Q9. Have you ever received a suspicious message, link or friend request?

Table 12: Q9 — Suspicious Messages / Requests: frequency distribution

Response option	Count	Percentage of respondents
Yes	45	81.8%
No	8	14.5%
Not sure	2	3.6%

Figure 9: Suspicious Messages / Requests (n = 55)**Figure 9: Suspicious Messages / Requests**

Forty-five respondents (81.8 per cent) have received a suspicious message, link or friend request. Exposure to attempted fraud is therefore the norm rather than the exception, and awareness training can safely be framed around incidents respondents have already personally experienced.

4.4.10 Q10 — Response to a Suspicious Link

Q10. What do you usually do when you receive a suspicious link?

Table 13: Q10 — Response to a Suspicious Link: frequency distribution

Response option	Count	Percentage of respondents
Ignore or delete it	24	43.6%
Report and delete it	14	25.5%
Ask someone before taking any action	9	16.4%
I'm not sure	6	10.9%
Open it to see what it contains	2	3.6%

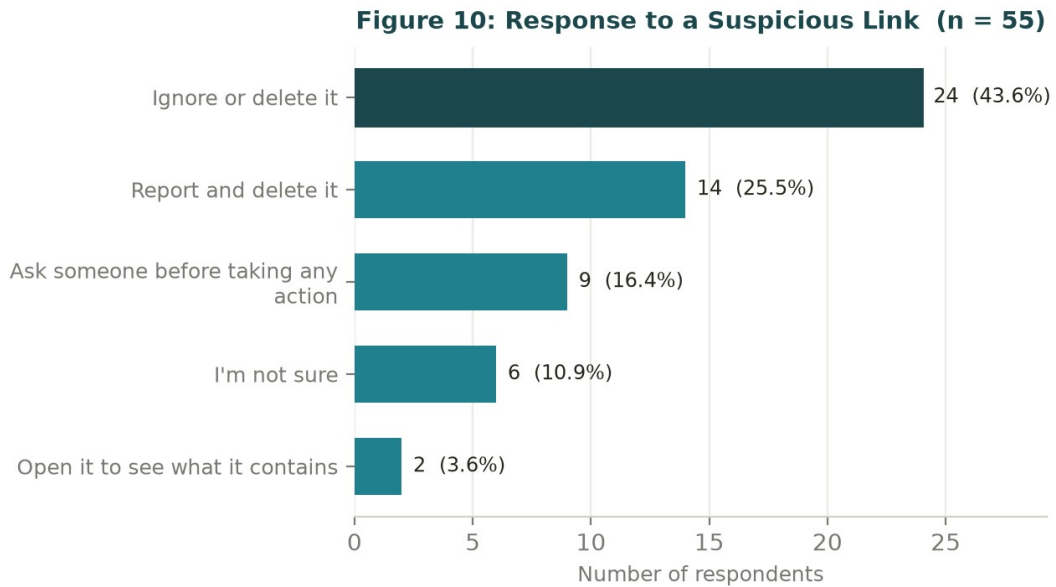


Figure 10: Response to a Suspicious Link

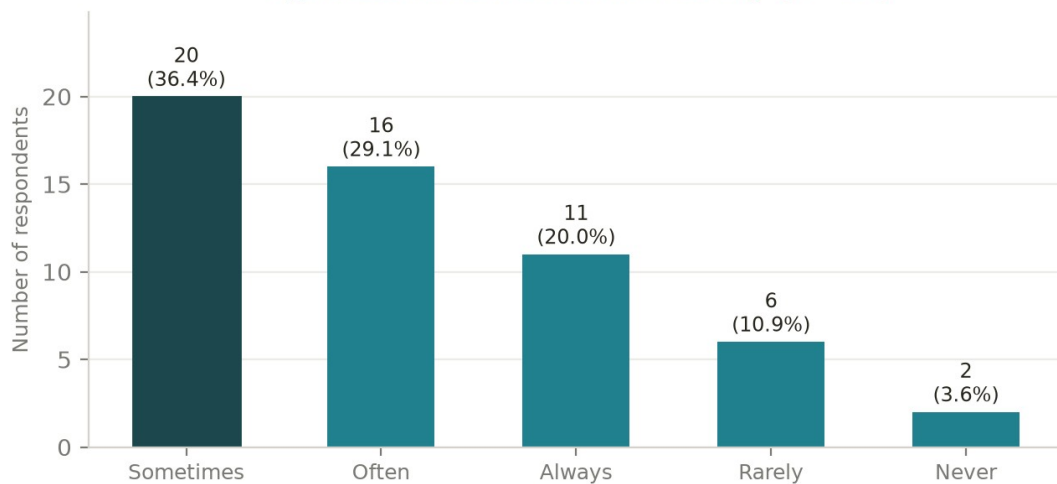
Thirty-eight respondents (69.1 per cent) would ignore, delete or report a suspicious link, which is the appropriate response. However, nine would first ask someone, six are unsure and two would open the link to see what it contains. Taken together, 17 respondents — nearly one in three — lack a settled safe response, and the two who would open the link are at immediate risk. A simple, memorable rule and knowledge of the 1930 helpline and the reporting portal would address this directly.

4.4.11 Q11 — Reflection Before Posting

Q11. *Do you think about future consequences before posting content online?*

Table 14: Q11 — Reflection Before Posting: frequency distribution

Response option	Count	Percentage of respondents
Sometimes	20	36.4%
Often	16	29.1%
Always	11	20.0%
Rarely	6	10.9%
Never	2	3.6%

Figure 11: Reflection Before Posting (n = 55)**Figure 11: Reflection Before Posting**

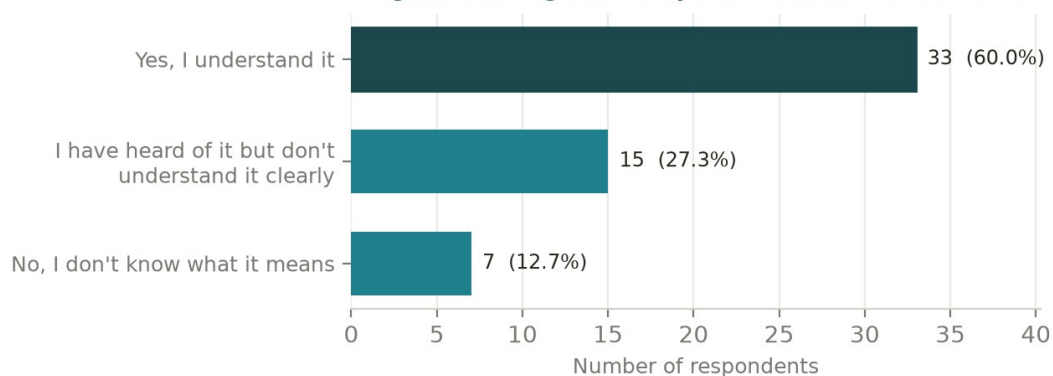
Twenty-seven respondents (49.1 per cent) always or often consider the consequences before posting, 20 do so sometimes, and eight rarely or never. Reflection is thus common but not habitual, and this partial attention aligns with the finding on public sharing in Q14.

4.4.12 Q12 — Digital-Footprint Awareness

Q12. Do you know what the term “digital footprint” means?

Table 15: Q12 — Digital-Footprint Awareness: frequency distribution

Response option	Count	Percentage of respondents
Yes, I understand it	33	60.0%
I have heard of it but don't understand it clearly	15	27.3%
No, I don't know what it means	7	12.7%

Figure 12: Digital-Footprint Awareness (n = 55)**Figure 12: Digital-Footprint Awareness**

Thirty-three respondents (60.0 per cent) say they understand the term “digital footprint”, 15 have heard of it without understanding it clearly and seven do not know it at all. Two in five respondents therefore lack a clear grasp of the central concept of this project. This closely echoes Survelioglu

and Seferoglu (2019), who found familiarity with the term lagging behind awareness of the underlying behaviours, and it confirms that the concept must be taught explicitly rather than assumed.

4.4.13 Q13 — Impact of Posts on Future Opportunities

Q13. Do you believe your online posts can affect future education or job opportunities?

Table 16: Q13 — Impact of Posts on Future Opportunities: frequency distribution

Response option	Count	Percentage of respondents
Yes	44	80.0%
Not sure	8	14.5%
No	3	5.5%

**Figure 13: Impact of Posts on Future Opportunities
(n = 55)**

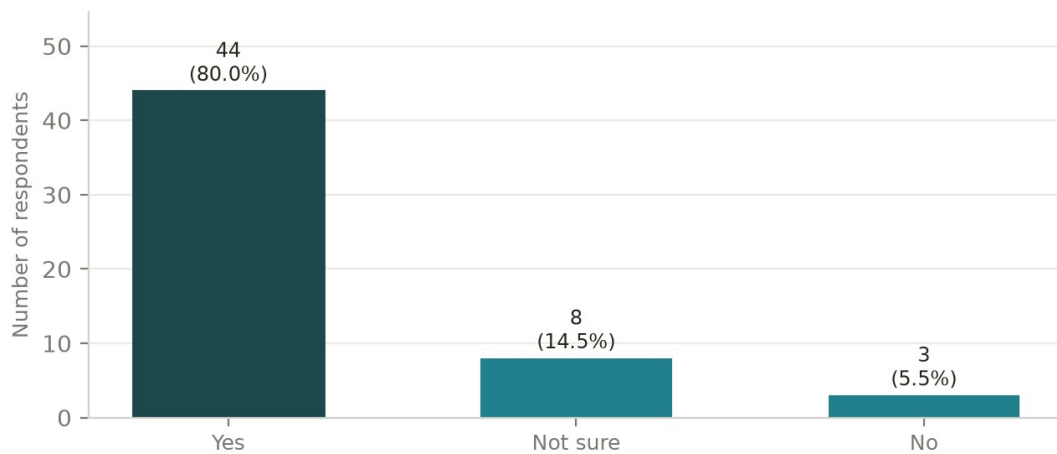


Figure 13: Impact of Posts on Future Opportunities

Forty-four respondents (80.0 per cent) believe their online posts can affect future education or employment opportunities; only three disagree. Awareness of long-term reputational consequence is thus the strongest single finding in the study and provides a persuasive entry point for awareness work, because respondents already accept the premise that online activity carries future cost.

4.4.14 Q14 — Public Sharing of Personal Information

Q14. How often do you share personal information (phone number, address, location) publicly?

Table 17: Q14 — Public Sharing of Personal Information: frequency distribution

Response option	Count	Percentage of respondents
Rarely	24	43.6%
Never	17	30.9%
Sometimes	11	20.0%
Often	3	5.5%

**Figure 14: Public Sharing of Personal Information
(n = 55)**

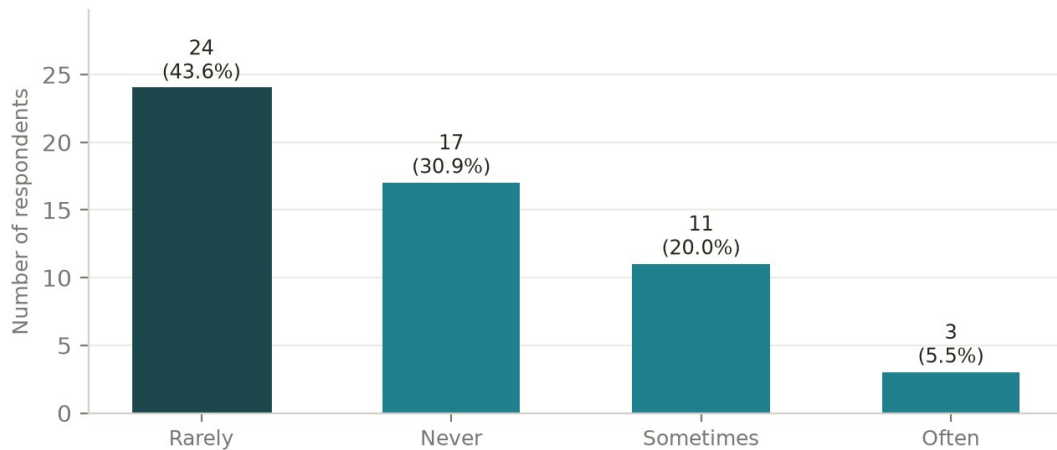


Figure 14: Public Sharing of Personal Information

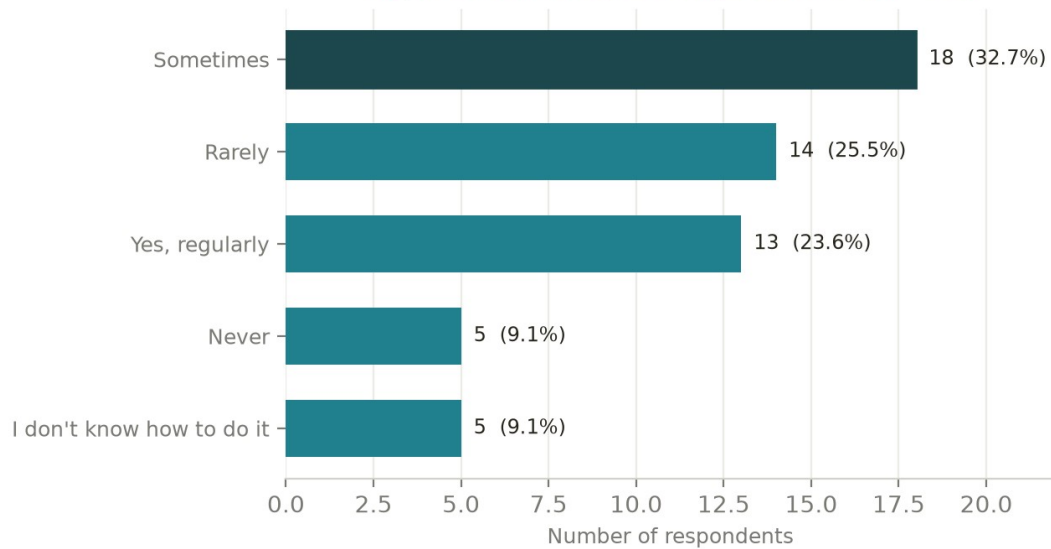
Forty-one respondents (74.5 per cent) never or rarely share personal information publicly, but 11 do so sometimes and three often. The 14 respondents who share at least sometimes are of particular concern when read alongside Q6, since public sharing from a public account is visible to anyone.

4.4.15 Q15 — Privacy-Settings Review

Q15. Do you review the privacy settings of your social-media accounts?

Table 18: Q15 — Privacy-Settings Review: frequency distribution

Response option	Count	Percentage of respondents
Sometimes	18	32.7%
Rarely	14	25.5%
Yes, regularly	13	23.6%
Never	5	9.1%
I don't know how to do it	5	9.1%

Figure 15: Privacy-Settings Review (n = 55)**Figure 15: Privacy-Settings Review**

Only 13 respondents (23.6 per cent) review their privacy settings regularly. Eighteen do so sometimes, 14 rarely, five never and five do not know how. Privacy review is thus the least established habit in the study, and the five respondents who do not know how to review settings represent a purely instructional gap that a ten-minute demonstration could close.

4.4.16 Q16 — Knowledge of Blocking / Reporting

Q16. Do you know how to block or report an account that harasses or misleads you?

Table 19: Q16 — Knowledge of Blocking / Reporting: frequency distribution

Response option	Count	Percentage of respondents
Yes	42	76.4%
Not sure	7	12.7%
No	6	10.9%

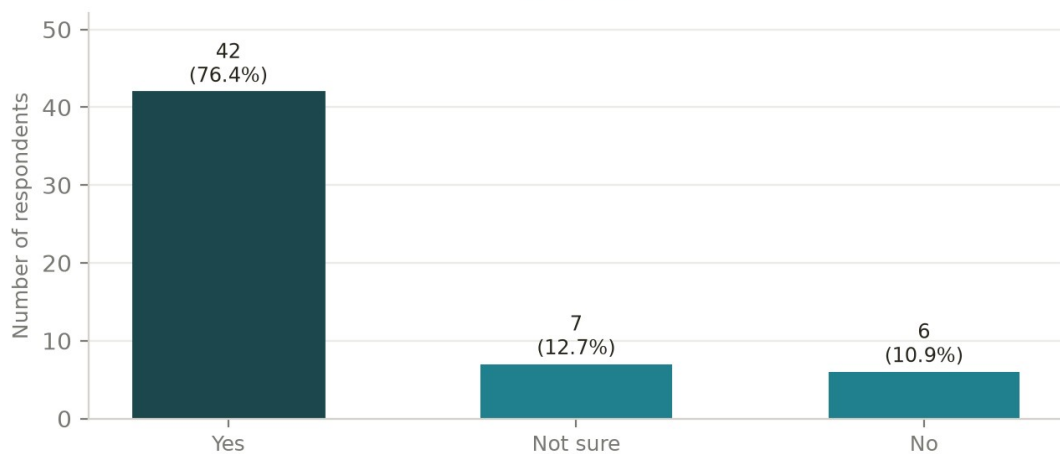
Figure 16: Knowledge of Blocking / Reporting (n = 55)

Figure 16: Knowledge of Blocking / Reporting

Forty-two respondents (76.4 per cent) know how to block or report an account, which is a genuine strength. Thirteen respondents remain uncertain or unable, however, and these are precisely the users least equipped to act when harassment or impersonation occurs.

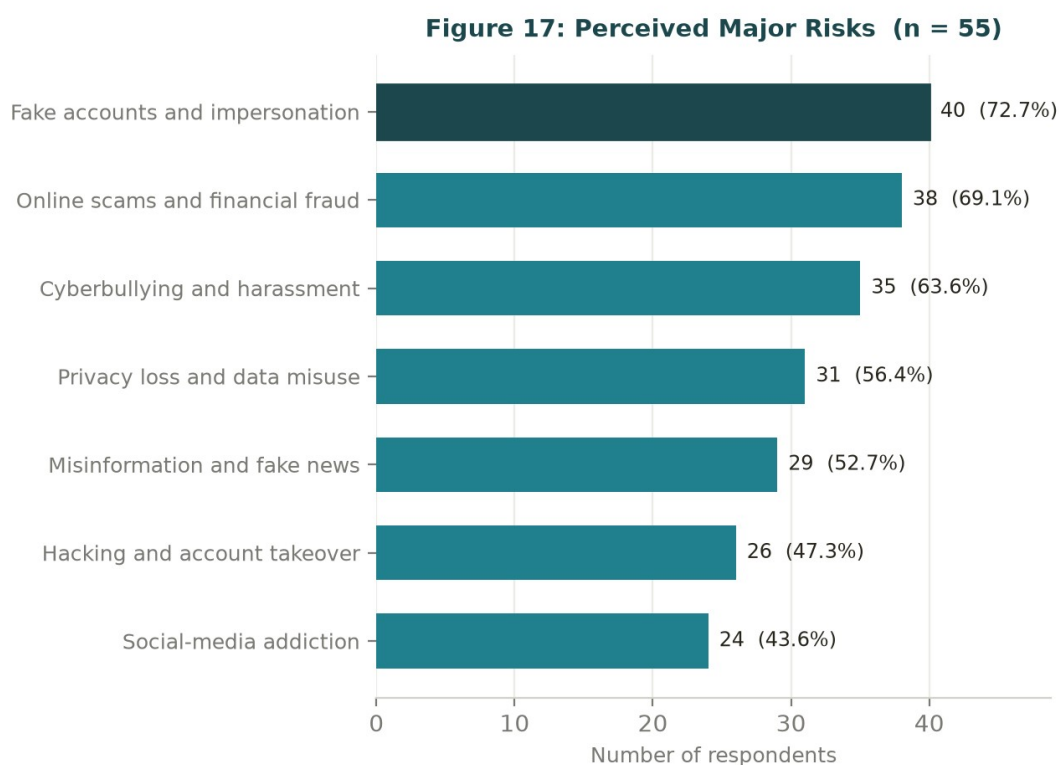
4.4.17 Q17 — Perceived Major Risks

Q17. Which of these do you consider the biggest social-media risks? (Select all that apply)

Table 20: Q17 — Perceived Major Risks: frequency distribution

Response option	Count	Percentage of respondents
Fake accounts and impersonation	40	72.7%
Online scams and financial fraud	38	69.1%
Cyberbullying and harassment	35	63.6%
Privacy loss and data misuse	31	56.4%
Misinformation and fake news	29	52.7%
Hacking and account takeover	26	47.3%
Social-media addiction	24	43.6%

Multiple-selection item: respondents could choose more than one option, so the 223 selections recorded exceed the 55 respondents and the percentages sum to more than 100 per cent.

**Figure 17: Perceived Major Risks**

Fake accounts and impersonation (40 selections) and online scams and financial fraud (38) are seen as the most serious risks, followed by cyberbullying (35) and privacy loss (31). Respondents' risk perception aligns closely with official data, in which fraud and cheating account for the largest share of recorded cybercrime in India (Ministry of Home Affairs, 2026). Notably, hacking and

account takeover ranks sixth, which may help explain the low adoption of two-factor authentication recorded in Q8: the specific risk that 2FA prevents is the one respondents worry about least.

4.4.18 Q18 — Confidence in Identifying Scams

Q18. On a scale of 1 to 5, how confident are you in identifying an online scam?

Table 21: Q18 — Confidence in Identifying Scams: frequency distribution

Response option	Count	Percentage of respondents
3 – Moderately confident	19	34.5%
4	17	30.9%
5 – Very confident	9	16.4%
2	7	12.7%
1 – Not confident	3	5.5%

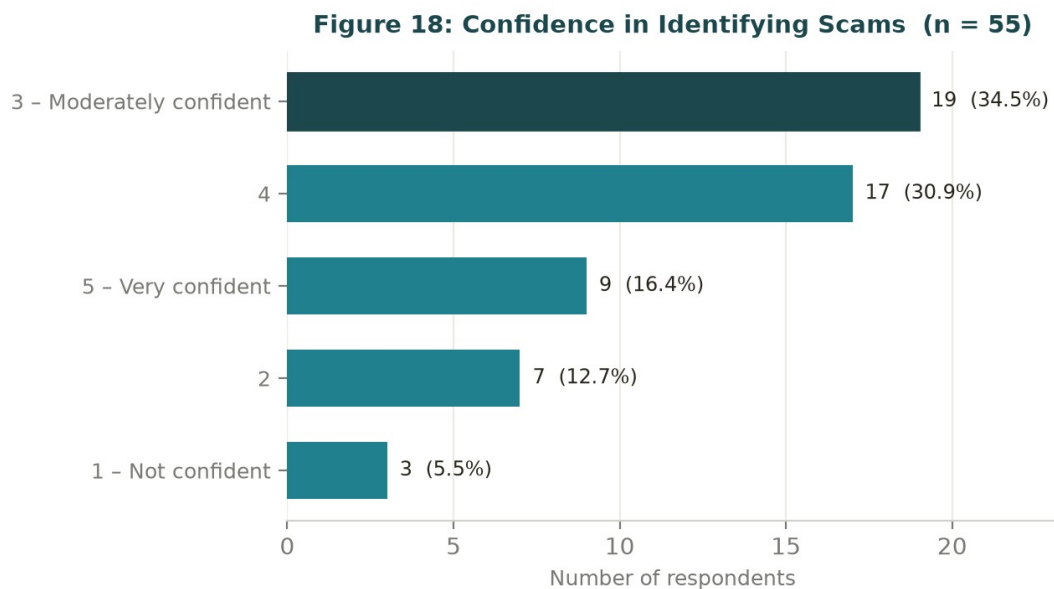


Figure 18: Confidence in Identifying Scams

Twenty-six respondents (47.3 per cent) rate their confidence in identifying a scam at 4 or 5, while 10 place themselves at 1 or 2 and 19 at the midpoint. Confidence is thus moderate rather than high. Read against the 81.8 per cent who have actually encountered a suspicious message in Q9, exposure clearly exceeds confidence, which is a strong argument for practical scam-identification exercises using real examples.

4.4.19 Q19 — Behaviour Change After Learning of a Risk

Q19. Have you changed any online habit after learning about a social-media risk?

Table 22: Q19 — Behaviour Change After Learning of a Risk: frequency distribution

Response option	Count	Percentage of respondents
Yes	28	50.9%
Partially	17	30.9%

Response option	Count	Percentage of respondents
No	10	18.2%

**Figure 19: Behaviour Change After Learning of a Risk
(n = 55)**

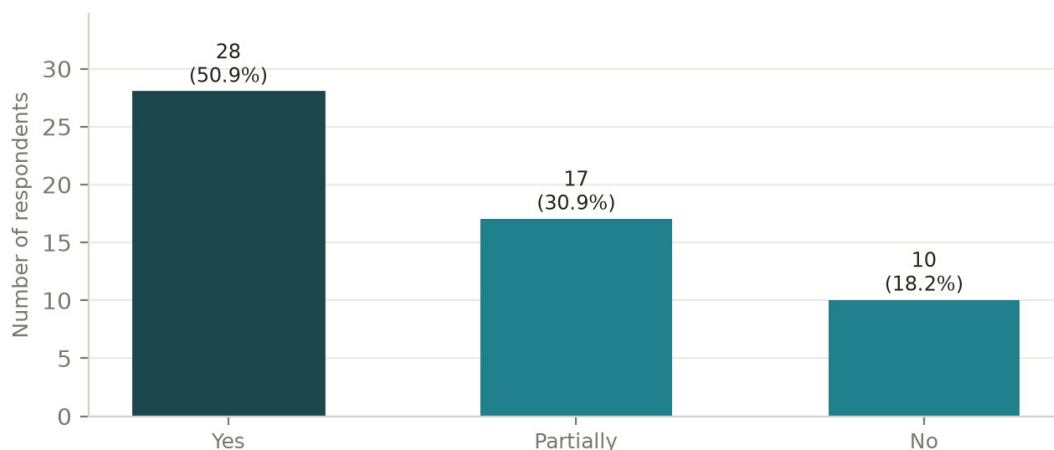


Figure 19: Behaviour Change After Learning of a Risk

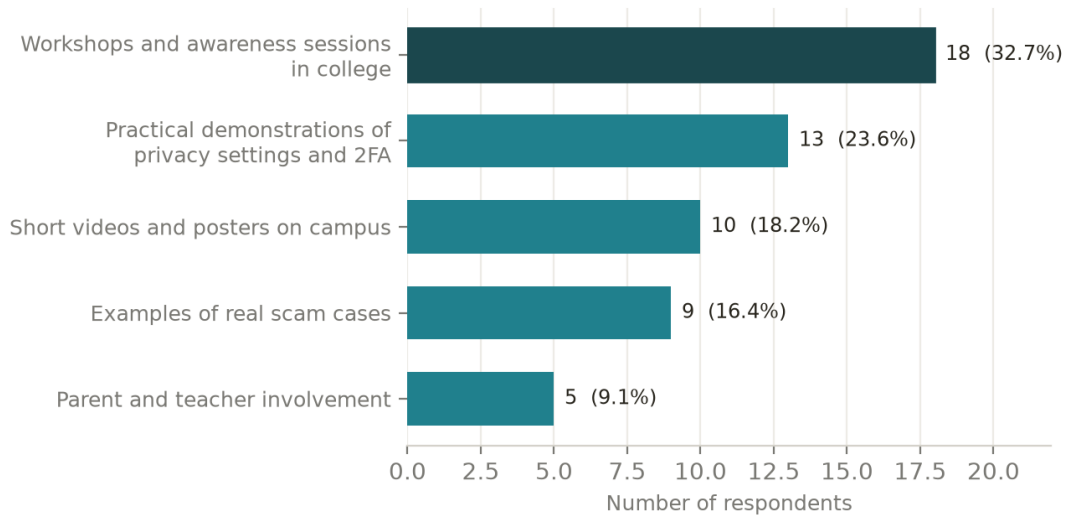
Twenty-eight respondents (50.9 per cent) have changed an online habit after learning of a risk and 17 have done so partially, while 10 report no change. That four in five respondents have altered behaviour at least partially is encouraging: awareness interventions in this community can reasonably be expected to produce some behavioural response, though the depth of that change is uncertain.

4.4.20 Q20 — Suggestions for Improving Awareness

Q20. What would help improve social-media safety awareness in your community? (Open-ended, coded)

Table 23: Q20 — Suggestions for Improving Awareness: frequency distribution

Response option	Count	Percentage of respondents
Workshops and awareness sessions in college	18	32.7%
Practical demonstrations of privacy settings and 2FA	13	23.6%
Short videos and posters on campus	10	18.2%
Examples of real scam cases	9	16.4%
Parent and teacher involvement	5	9.1%

Figure 20: Suggestions for Improving Awareness (n = 55)**Figure 20: Suggestions for Improving Awareness**

When asked what would help, 18 respondents proposed workshops and awareness sessions and 13 asked specifically for practical demonstrations of privacy settings and two-factor authentication. Ten suggested short videos and posters, nine wanted examples of real scam cases and five recommended involving parents and teachers. The community's own preference is therefore clearly for hands-on, demonstrative formats rather than passive information.

4.4.21 Q21 — Interest in Learning More

Q21. Would you be interested in attending a session on online privacy and safety?

Table 24: Q21 — Interest in Learning More: frequency distribution

Response option	Count	Percentage of respondents
Yes	41	74.5%
Maybe	11	20.0%
No	3	5.5%

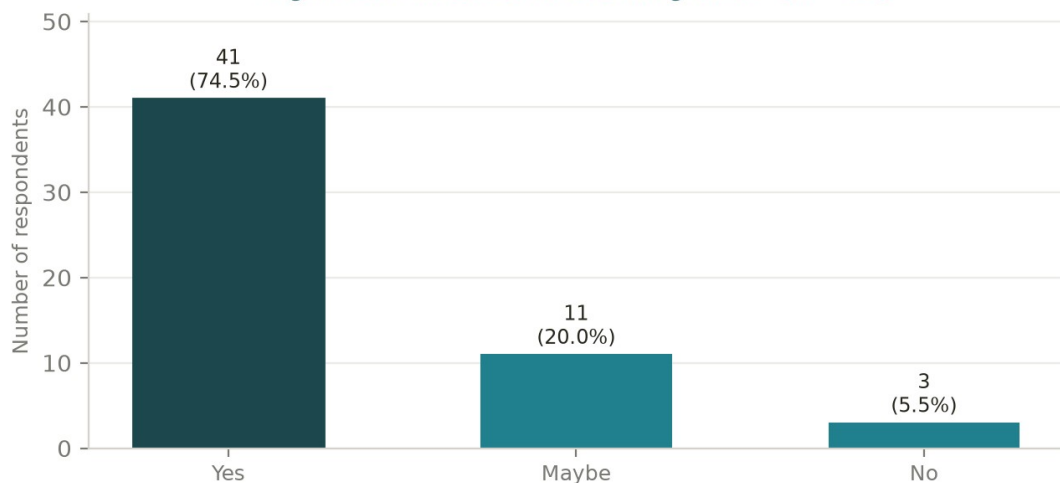
Figure 21: Interest in Learning More (n = 55)

Figure 21: Interest in Learning More

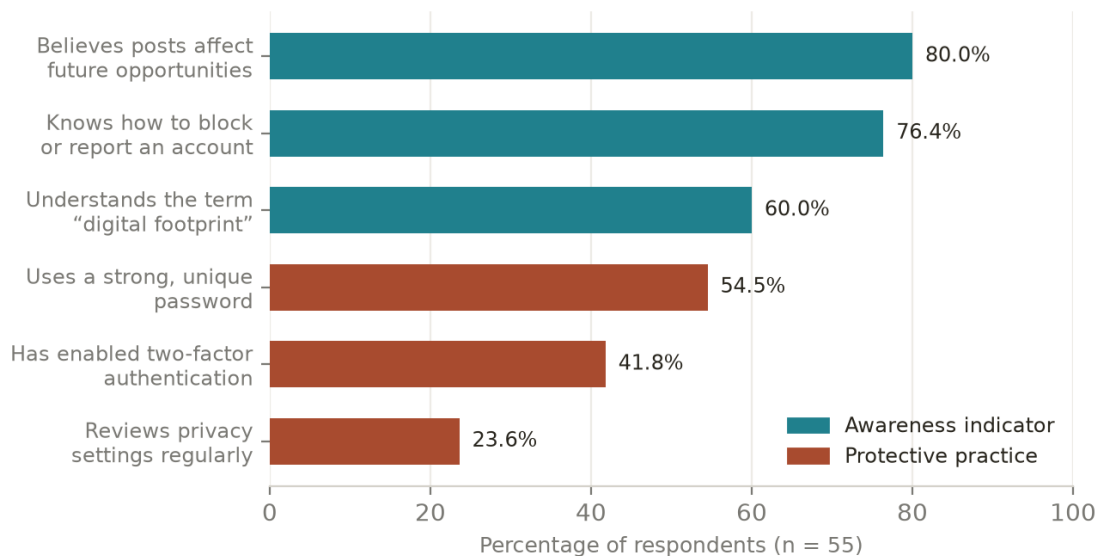
Forty-one respondents (74.5 per cent) would attend a session on online privacy and safety and 11 might; only three would not. Willingness to participate is high, which means the recommendations in Chapter 5 rest on demonstrated demand rather than assumption.

4.5 Cross-cutting Observations

Reading the items against one another produces the central finding of this study. When the three awareness indicators are placed beside the three protective practices they ought to produce, a consistent gap appears.

Table 25: Awareness indicators compared with protective practices

Awareness indicator	%	Corresponding practice	%
Believes posts affect future opportunities (Q13)	80.0%	Reviews privacy settings regularly (Q15)	23.6%
Knows how to block or report an account (Q16)	76.4%	Has enabled two-factor authentication (Q8)	41.8%
Understands the term "digital footprint" (Q12)	60.0%	Uses a strong, unique password (Q7)	54.5%

Figure 22: Awareness Indicators Compared with Protective Practices**Figure 22: Awareness Indicators Compared with Protective Practices**

The pattern is unambiguous. Awareness indicators cluster between 60 and 80 per cent, while the practices that would act on that awareness cluster between 24 and 55 per cent. The widest single gap is between the 80.0 per cent who believe their posts affect future opportunities and the 23.6 per cent who regularly review the settings that govern who can see those posts — a difference of 56.4 percentage points. This is the awareness-to-action gap described in Section 2.5, measured within a single community.

Three further connections are worth noting. First, exposure exceeds confidence: 81.8 per cent have received a suspicious message (Q9) while only 47.3 per cent are confident of identifying a scam (Q18), so a substantial group is encountering fraud attempts without feeling equipped to judge them. Second, the risks respondents fear do not match the protections they adopt — hacking and account takeover ranks only sixth among perceived risks (Q17), which is consistent with the low uptake of two-factor authentication (Q8). Third, the group most at risk is compound rather than large: the 15 respondents with public accounts (Q6) overlap with the 14 who share personal information at least sometimes (Q14) and the 19 who rarely or never review privacy settings (Q15), and it is this overlap, rather than any single answer, that identifies the priority audience for intervention.

4.6 Key Findings of the Field Study

- Social media use is intensive: 60.0 per cent of respondents spend more than three hours online daily, and WhatsApp, Instagram and YouTube are the dominant platforms.
- Awareness of reputational risk is high, with 80.0 per cent accepting that posts can affect future education or employment opportunities.
- The core concept remains partly unfamiliar: 40.0 per cent do not clearly understand the term “digital footprint”.
- Technical protection is weak. Two-factor authentication is enabled by only 41.8 per cent and eight respondents do not know what it is; regular privacy review stands at 23.6 per cent.
- Exposure to fraud attempts is near-universal at 81.8 per cent, yet only 47.3 per cent are confident of identifying a scam, and 17 respondents have no settled safe response to a suspicious link.
- Knowledge of blocking and reporting tools is a genuine strength at 76.4 per cent, though 13 respondents remain unable or unsure.
- The gap between awareness and practice reaches 56.4 percentage points on the privacy-review indicator and constitutes the central finding of the study.
- Demand for intervention is strong and specific: 74.5 per cent would attend a session, and respondents themselves asked most often for workshops and hands-on demonstrations.

CHAPTER 5 — CONCLUSION AND RECOMMENDATIONS

5.1 Conclusion

This field project set out to measure social media safety and digital footprint awareness in a defined local community and to establish how far that awareness has translated into protective behaviour. On the evidence of 55 responses, the community is intensively connected, broadly conscious of risk, and inconsistently protected.

The objectives stated in Section 1.3 were met. Usage patterns were established: three in five respondents spend more than three hours a day on social media, concentrated on WhatsApp, Instagram and YouTube. Account-security practice was measured and found uneven, with two-factor authentication at 41.8 per cent the weakest indicator recorded. Awareness of the digital footprint was measured at 60.0 per cent for the term itself but 80.0 per cent for its practical implication, indicating that the idea is understood more widely than the vocabulary. Perceived risks were identified, with fake accounts and financial fraud ranking highest, closely matching the pattern in official Indian cybercrime statistics. And the awareness-to-action gap was quantified, reaching 56.4 percentage points between belief in future consequences and regular privacy review.

The principal conclusion is therefore that this community does not need to be persuaded that online risk is real. It needs to be shown, concretely and individually, how to act on a belief it already holds. Respondents who could describe the danger of a fake profile in detail had frequently never opened their own privacy settings, and respondents who used one-time passwords daily for banking did not know the same protection was available on their social accounts. The deficit is procedural, not attitudinal, which is encouraging: procedural gaps close faster than attitudes change, and the 74.5 per cent willingness to attend a session indicates that the community is ready to be shown.

5.2 Recommendations

For the college and the community

- Conduct a hands-on digital-safety workshop each semester in which participants enable two-factor authentication and review their privacy settings on their own devices during the session, rather than being told about them afterwards.
- Run scam-identification drills using real screenshots of the lottery messages, fake job offers, duplicate profiles and fraudulent customer-care numbers that respondents described during the fieldwork.
- Publicise the National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal and the 1930 helpline on notice boards, in the library and on college social media accounts, so that a concrete reporting route is known before it is needed.
- Train a small group of student digital-safety volunteers who can help peers configure settings, making support available continuously rather than only on workshop days.
- Introduce a short digital-citizenship module in the induction programme for first-year students, covering the digital footprint, privacy defaults and safe response to suspicious contact.

For individual users

- Enable two-factor authentication on every social media and email account, beginning with the account used for password recovery.
- Set the main account to private and use a unique password for each service, ideally managed through a password manager.
- Review privacy settings once every three months, and treat the review as a fixed routine rather than a response to an incident.
- Search for your own name periodically to see the footprint others can find, and remove or restrict what no longer reflects you.
- Never open an unexpected link; verify through a separate, known channel, and report and delete rather than merely ignoring.
- Avoid publishing phone numbers, addresses, live location and travel plans, and pause before posting anything that would be uncomfortable if seen by a teacher, an employer or a family member.

5.3 Suggested Action Plan for the Community

Table 26 converts the recommendations into a sequenced plan with indicators that can be verified after implementation, so that the effect of the intervention can be measured rather than assumed.

Table 26: Suggested action plan for the community

Priority	Action	Responsibility	Success indicator
Immediate	Two-factor authentication setup drive during a class hour	IT department, student volunteers	2FA adoption rises from 41.8% to above 75%
Immediate	Privacy-settings review clinic in the library	Student volunteers	Every participant completes one review
Short term	Scam-identification session using real case screenshots	Project team, faculty guide	Confidence rating of 4 or 5 rises above 70%
Short term	Display of the 1930 helpline and reporting-portal details	College administration	Awareness of the reporting route above 80%
Medium term	Digital-citizenship module in first-year induction	Academic coordinator	Module delivered to every new cohort
Medium term	Repeat survey after six months	Next project cohort	Measurable narrowing of the awareness-practice gap

5.4 Scope for Future Work

Several extensions would strengthen the evidence produced here. A larger and more varied sample, including more school students, older adults and non-student community members, would permit comparison across groups rather than description of a single one. A pre-test and post-test design around a workshop would measure whether an intervention actually changes behaviour, which the present cross-sectional design cannot establish. Administering the questionnaire in Hindi and Marathi alongside English would widen participation. Adding a short practical task — asking

respondents to demonstrate where the privacy settings are, rather than to report whether they use them — would reduce reliance on self-report. Finally, repeating the survey after six months, as proposed in Table 26, would show whether the gap identified in Section 4.5 has narrowed.

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APPENDIX A — QUESTIONNAIRE USED IN THE FIELD SURVEY

The following instrument was administered to all 55 respondents through Google Forms. Response options are listed as presented to respondents. No item requested a name, password, account handle, telephone number or address.

Title of the form: Social Media Safety & Digital Footprint Awareness — Community Engagement Project Survey

Introductory text shown to respondents: This short questionnaire is part of an academic field project on social media safety. It takes about six minutes. Participation is voluntary and your responses are anonymous. Please do not enter your name or any password.

Q1. What is your age group?

- 18–24
- 13–17
- 25–34
- 35–44

[Single choice]

Q2. What is your current occupation or status?

- College/university student
- School student
- Working professional
- Other

[Single choice]

Q3. On average, how much time do you spend on social media each day?

- 3–5 hours per day
- 1–3 hours per day
- More than 5 hours per day
- Less than 1 hour per day

[Single choice]

Q4. Which social-media platforms do you use most frequently? (Select all that apply)

- WhatsApp
- Instagram
- YouTube
- Snapchat
- X (Twitter)
- LinkedIn
- Facebook
- Telegram

[Multiple selection (choose all that apply)]

Q5. What do you mainly use social media for? (Select all that apply)

- Communication with friends and family
- Entertainment
- News and information
- Education and study material
- Content creation
- Professional networking
- Online shopping

[Multiple selection (choose all that apply)]

Q6. Is your main social-media account set to private?

- Yes
- No
- Not sure

[Single choice]

Q7. Do you use a strong and unique password for your social-media accounts?

- Yes
- No
- Not sure

[Single choice]

Q8. Have you enabled two-factor authentication (2FA) on your accounts?

- No
- Yes
- I don't know what 2FA is

[Single choice]

Q9. Have you ever received a suspicious message, link or friend request?

- Yes
- No
- Not sure

[Single choice]

Q10. What do you usually do when you receive a suspicious link?

- Ignore or delete it
- Report and delete it
- Ask someone before taking any action
- I'm not sure
- Open it to see what it contains

[Single choice]

Q11. Do you think about future consequences before posting content online?

- Sometimes
- Often
- Always

- Rarely
- Never

[Single choice]

Q12. Do you know what the term “digital footprint” means?

- Yes, I understand it
- I have heard of it but don't understand it clearly
- No, I don't know what it means

[Single choice]

Q13. Do you believe your online posts can affect future education or job opportunities?

- Yes
- Not sure
- No

[Single choice]

Q14. How often do you share personal information (phone number, address, location) publicly?

- Rarely
- Never
- Sometimes
- Often

[Single choice]

Q15. Do you review the privacy settings of your social-media accounts?

- Sometimes
- Rarely
- Yes, regularly
- Never
- I don't know how to do it

[Single choice]

Q16. Do you know how to block or report an account that harasses or misleads you?

- Yes
- Not sure
- No

[Single choice]

Q17. Which of these do you consider the biggest social-media risks? (Select all that apply)

- Fake accounts and impersonation
- Online scams and financial fraud
- Cyberbullying and harassment
- Privacy loss and data misuse
- Misinformation and fake news
- Hacking and account takeover
- Social-media addiction

[Multiple selection (choose all that apply)]

Q18. On a scale of 1 to 5, how confident are you in identifying an online scam?

- 3 – Moderately confident
- 4
- 5 – Very confident
- 2
- 1 – Not confident

[Five-point scale]

Q19. Have you changed any online habit after learning about a social-media risk?

- Yes
- Partially
- No

[Single choice]

Q20. What would help improve social-media safety awareness in your community? (Open-ended, coded)

- Workshops and awareness sessions in college
- Practical demonstrations of privacy settings and 2FA
- Short videos and posters on campus
- Examples of real scam cases
- Parent and teacher involvement

[Single choice]

Q21. Would you be interested in attending a session on online privacy and safety?

- Yes
- Maybe
- No

[Single choice]

Q20 was administered as an open-ended question; the five categories listed above are the codes into which the free-text answers were grouped during analysis.

APPENDIX B — RAW RESPONSE DATA (55 RESPONDENTS)

The complete response set is reproduced below in coded form. Each row is one respondent, identified by a serial code only. Table 27 gives the code for every response option and Table 28 presents the response matrix. For the three multiple-selection items (Q4, Q5 and Q17) the cell lists every code the respondent selected.

Table 27: Response coding legend for the raw data matrix

Item	Short title	Codes
Q1	Age Group	a = 18–24; b = 13–17; c = 25–34; d = 35–44
Q2	Occupation / Status	a = College/university student; b = School student; c = Working professional; d = Other
Q3	Daily Social-Media Usage	a = 3–5 hours per day; b = 1–3 hours per day; c = More than 5 hours per day; d = Less than 1 hour per day
Q4	Platforms Used Most Frequently	a = WhatsApp; b = Instagram; c = YouTube; d = Snapchat; e = X (Twitter); f = LinkedIn; g = Facebook; h = Telegram
Q5	Primary Purpose of Use	a = Communication with friends and family; b = Entertainment; c = News and information; d = Education and study material; e = Content creation; f = Professional networking; g = Online shopping
Q6	Account Privacy Status	a = Yes; b = No; c = Not sure
Q7	Password Practices	a = Yes; b = No; c = Not sure
Q8	Two-Factor Authentication	a = No; b = Yes; c = I don't know what 2FA is
Q9	Suspicious Messages / Requests	a = Yes; b = No; c = Not sure
Q10	Response to a Suspicious Link	a = Ignore or delete it; b = Report and delete it; c = Ask someone before taking any action; d = I'm not sure; e = Open it to see what it contains
Q11	Reflection Before Posting	a = Sometimes; b = Often; c = Always; d = Rarely; e = Never
Q12	Digital-Footprint Awareness	a = Yes, I understand it; b = I have heard of it but don't understand it clearly; c = No, I don't know what it means
Q13	Impact of Posts on Future Opportunities	a = Yes; b = Not sure; c = No
Q14	Public Sharing of Personal Information	a = Rarely; b = Never; c = Sometimes; d = Often
Q15	Privacy-Settings Review	a = Sometimes; b = Rarely; c = Yes, regularly; d = Never; e = I don't know how to do it
Q16	Knowledge of Blocking / Reporting	a = Yes; b = Not sure; c = No

Item	Short title	Codes
Q17	Perceived Major Risks	a = Fake accounts and impersonation; b = Online scams and financial fraud; c = Cyberbullying and harassment; d = Privacy loss and data misuse; e = Misinformation and fake news; f = Hacking and account takeover; g = Social-media addiction
Q18	Confidence in Identifying Scams	a = 3 – Moderately confident; b = 4; c = 5 – Very confident; d = 2; e = 1 – Not confident
Q19	Behaviour Change After Learning of a Risk	a = Yes; b = Partially; c = No
Q20	Suggestions for Improving Awareness	a = Workshops and awareness sessions in college; b = Practical demonstrations of privacy settings and 2FA; c = Short videos and posters on campus; d = Examples of real scam cases; e = Parent and teacher involvement
Q21	Interest in Learning More	a = Yes; b = Maybe; c = No

Table 28: Raw response matrix (55 respondents × 21 items)

ID	Q1	Q2	Q3	Q4	Q5	Q6	Q7	Q8	Q9	Q10	Q11	Q12	Q13	Q14	Q15	Q16	Q17	Q18	Q19	Q20	Q21
001	a	a	b	abcf	ad	b	a	b	a	d	a	c	c	a	d	a	acefg	b	c	a	b
002	a	c	b	abce	ac	a	a	a	a	c	a	b	a	a	a	a	abdf	d	a	b	c
003	a	a	d	acdfg	acg	a	b	b	a	c	b	b	b	b	b	a	abcf	a	b	b	b
004	a	a	a	abcdh	abcd	a	b	b	b	a	b	a	b	c	c	b	adf	c	c	a	b
005	c	a	a	abcdfh	ad	a	a	b	a	c	a	a	a	b	e	a	cdef	b	a	a	b
006	a	a	c	abcdf	abefg	a	c	b	a	c	d	a	a	a	a	b	abcdefg	c	a	a	a
007	a	a	b	abcdeg	abcf	a	a	a	a	d	c	b	a	a	e	a	abcfg	c	b	a	a
008	b	a	c	abcef	abcd	b	b	b	a	b	c	b	a	d	c	c	abce	d	c	a	c
009	c	c	b	abcdeg	abe	a	b	c	a	a	d	c	b	c	c	a	aeg	c	a	a	b
010	a	a	a	abcde	abcf	b	a	a	a	a	a	a	a	b	c	a	abdf	e	c	a	a
011	a	a	d	abcde	a	b	a	c	a	a	d	a	a	a	a	a	bdefg	b	b	e	a
012	b	a	b	abcg	abcd	a	b	a	a	c	c	b	a	a	a	a	aeg	a	b	c	a
013	a	d	a	abce	abcd	b	c	b	a	d	b	b	a	b	b	a	bdefg	d	b	c	a
014	b	b	b	adfg	abde	a	a	a	a	a	a	a	b	a	d	b	abdefg	c	a	d	a
015	a	a	b	abcdh	c	b	a	b	b	a	c	a	b	a	b	c	befg	a	c	c	a
016	a	a	d	abcf	def	a	a	a	a	b	c	a	a	a	c	c	bc	c	c	d	a
017	c	d	b	abd	b	a	a	a	a	a	a	a	a	b	a	a	abcdf	a	b	d	a
018	a	a	b	abcdfg	abcdf	b	b	b	a	b	c	a	b	b	c	b	abef	d	a	b	a
019	a	a	c	abc	abcg	c	a	c	a	c	b	a	a	a	b	a	abceg	b	a	d	a
020	a	a	b	abcef	abcdf	b	b	a	a	b	b	a	a	a	d	a	abcdfg	a	a	a	a
021	a	a	a	abcdh	abf	a	a	a	a	b	b	c	a	a	b	c	acde	a	b	b	a
022	a	a	b	abd	abc	a	a	b	a	a	d	a	a	c	c	a	bcd	a	a	b	a
023	d	a	a	ab	abc	c	b	a	a	a	a	a	a	a	b	a	bcdg	b	b	c	a
024	a	a	b	abcg	bcef	a	c	a	c	a	d	a	a	b	b	a	abe	a	a	c	a
025	a	a	a	abf	abcg	b	b	a	b	a	a	a	a	b	e	a	abeg	b	a	d	a
026	b	a	b	abce	abdf	a	a	c	a	d	a	b	a	c	c	b	abce	e	a	c	a
027	a	a	a	abcdegh	abcde	b	c	c	a	c	c	c	a	c	a	c	beg	a	a	b	a
028	d	a	c	abcfg	ab	a	a	c	a	e	a	a	a	c	e	a	bcd	a	b	e	a
029	a	a	b	abcdfg	abcde	a	a	a	a	b	a	a	a	a	b	a	adfg	c	b	a	a
030	a	a	a	abcd	bcd	b	a	b	a	c	a	a	a	a	d	a	ac	a	b	c	a
031	a	a	a	acd	abce	a	c	b	a	a	b	a	b	a	a	b	abcde	b	a	b	a
032	a	a	c	abce	ab	c	c	a	a	c	b	b	b	d	b	c	acd	a	a	b	a
033	b	a	a	bdeh	abcdf	b	a	b	a	b	b	b	a	a	a	a	ac	d	a	c	b
034	a	c	b	abcde	abg	a	b	c	b	b	c	a	a	c	a	a	cdf	a	b	d	b
035	a	a	a	abce	abce	c	b	b	a	a	c	a	a	b	b	a	abcdfg	a	b	b	a
036	c	a	c	abcfh	abdfg	a	b	b	a	a	b	b	a	a	c	a	acg	e	b	d	b
037	b	a	c	acgh	abcdeg	a	c	a	c	a	c	a	c	c	a	a	abcde	a	a	d	a
038	a	b	a	abcdf	abd	a	b	b	b	a	b	a	a	b	c	a	eg	d	c	e	a
039	c	a	a	abcegh	abc	a	a	b	a	a	e	b	a	b	a	a	abcdg	b	a	a	a
040	a	b	a	abeg	bcd	a	c	b	b	b	b	b	a	a	a	a	abc	b	a	b	a
041	a	b	b	ab	abd	a	a	a	a	b	b	a	a	a	b	a	abc	b	b	a	b
042	a	a	a	abceh	adeg	a	b	a	a	b	a	a	a	a	e	a	abcefg	b	a	e	a
043	a	b	c	abcdh	g	b	a	b	a	a	a	a	a	c	c	a	abcde	c	a	b	b
044	a	a	a	abcdeh	abe	a	a	a	b	a	a	a	a	b	b	a	bcdeg	b	a	b	a
045	a	a	a	ab	acdeg	a	a	a	a	d	a	c	c	b	a	a	abcde	b	a	c	a
046	a	a	a	abc	bcde	a	c	b	a	b	b	c	a	a	b	a	abcdg	b	b	c	b

ID	Q1	Q2	Q3	Q4	Q5	Q6	Q7	Q8	Q9	Q10	Q11	Q12	Q13	Q14	Q15	Q16	Q17	Q18	Q19	Q20	Q21
047	a	b	a	bcf	acdf	a	a	a	a	a	a	a	a	a	b	a	abce	b	b	d	a
048	a	a	a	abcdf	abcd	a	a	b	a	e	b	c	a	c	d	b	adef	b	a	a	a
049	a	a	c	ad	b	b	a	a	a	a	b	a	a	d	a	a	bcef	a	c	a	a
050	a	c	b	bcd	acg	a	b	c	a	b	d	b	a	b	a	a	abdfg	d	a	a	a
051	a	a	c	abcd	ab	a	c	b	a	d	e	a	a	b	a	a	abcde	a	c	e	c
052	a	a	a	cdef	abf	a	a	a	a	b	a	a	a	c	a	a	bdg	b	a	a	a
053	a	c	b	abcef	abcdg	b	a	b	a	a	c	b	a	a	c	a	ade	a	a	a	a
054	a	a	b	abce	abcd	a	a	a	a	a	a	b	a	b	a	a	d	a	a	b	a
055	c	a	c	abg	abcde	a	a	a	b	a	a	a	a	b	c	a	acf	c	c	a	a

Multiple-selection items (Q4, Q5, Q17) show all codes selected by that respondent. Serial identifiers replace names; no identifying information was collected.

APPENDIX C — FIELDWORK EVIDENCE AND PHOTOGRAPH RECORD

This appendix records the documentary evidence of the fieldwork. The checklist in Table 29 lists each item, its status and where it is held. Photographs were taken only with the express permission of the persons appearing in them; faces may be masked in the printed copy where a respondent requested it.

Table 29: Fieldwork evidence and photograph record

No.	Evidence item	Date	Status
1	Google Forms response sheet exported to spreadsheet (55 records)	22 Aug 2026	Held by the student
2	Printed copy of the questionnaire as administered	4 Aug 2026	Attached
3	Photograph — questionnaire administration on campus	8 Aug 2026	Paste below
4	Photograph — group interaction and discussion session	12 Aug 2026	Paste below
5	Photograph — privacy-settings demonstration with a respondent	18 Aug 2026	Paste below
6	Field notes recording observations during interactions	4–22 Aug 2026	Held by the student
7	Permission note from the college for campus data collection	1 Aug 2026	Attached
8	Attendance/consent sheet for the group interaction	12 Aug 2026	Attached

Photograph Record

Paste the field photographs in the spaces below and complete the caption line under each. Captions should state the date, the place and what the photograph shows.

[Paste photograph here]

Photograph 1 — Administration of the questionnaire on the college campus, 8 August 2026

[Paste photograph here]

Photograph 2 — Group interaction and discussion session, 12 August 2026

[Paste photograph here]

Photograph 3 — Demonstration of privacy settings with a respondent, 18 August 2026